



100 Talk is Cheap



103 Bug Hunters

Digital Business

How Technology Can Help Your Organisation

Case Study

Milking For Tomorrow

A scientific and tech-enabled approach to dairy animal keeping can significantly boost the country's milk production, at the village, zonal and state levels

Philip Malayil

Old-timers will remember the days when milk was a rationed commodity. You got up early in the morning, took your milk-card to the nearest milk booth, and picked up an allotted quantity. Operation Flood changed all that: not only did milk become available in whatever quantity you wanted, India became the largest milk producer in the world.

While this may sound impressive, veterinarians are not quite impressed. Dr Abdul Samad, Head of the Department of Medicine at Bombay Veterinary College says, "We may be the largest producer of milk, but this is from the largest population of cows in the world."

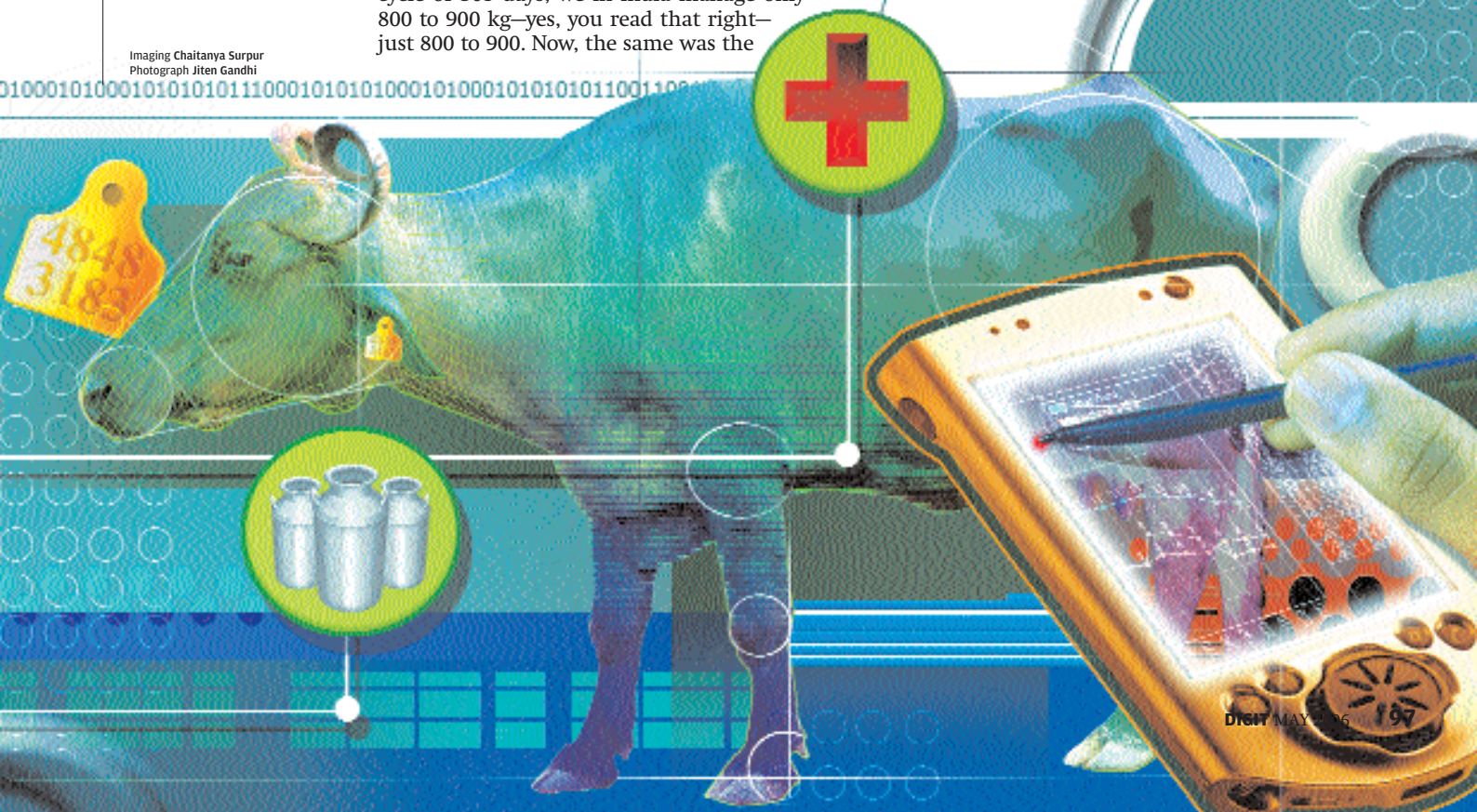
Milking Tech

What Dr Samad is referring to is that when some countries in the world are able to milk 10,000 kilograms of milk from a cow during a lactation cycle of 305 days, we in India manage only 800 to 900 kg—yes, you read that right—just 800 to 900. Now, the same was the

case in countries such as Egypt and Israel about 30 years ago. Today's figures in those countries stand at 12,000 kilograms. The secret, according to Dr Samad, is a scientific approach to the problem—a system of data recording that enables identifying genetically good animals for breeding, analysis of trends, and the prediction of fertility and production problems.

Towards this end, Dr Samad is conducting several pilot projects, one of which is at the farm in Bhilwadi (district Sangli), from where Chitale Bandhu, perhaps Pune's most well-known sweet shop, gets its milk. In collaboration with Mumbai-based Infovet, he has developed a dairy animal health and productivity management software called Herdman. Infovet has also developed other software such as SemenPerfect for semen centres and progeny testing—an important activity for genetic improvement of

Imaging Chaitanya Surpur
Photograph Jiten Gandhi



DIGIT MAY 2006 197